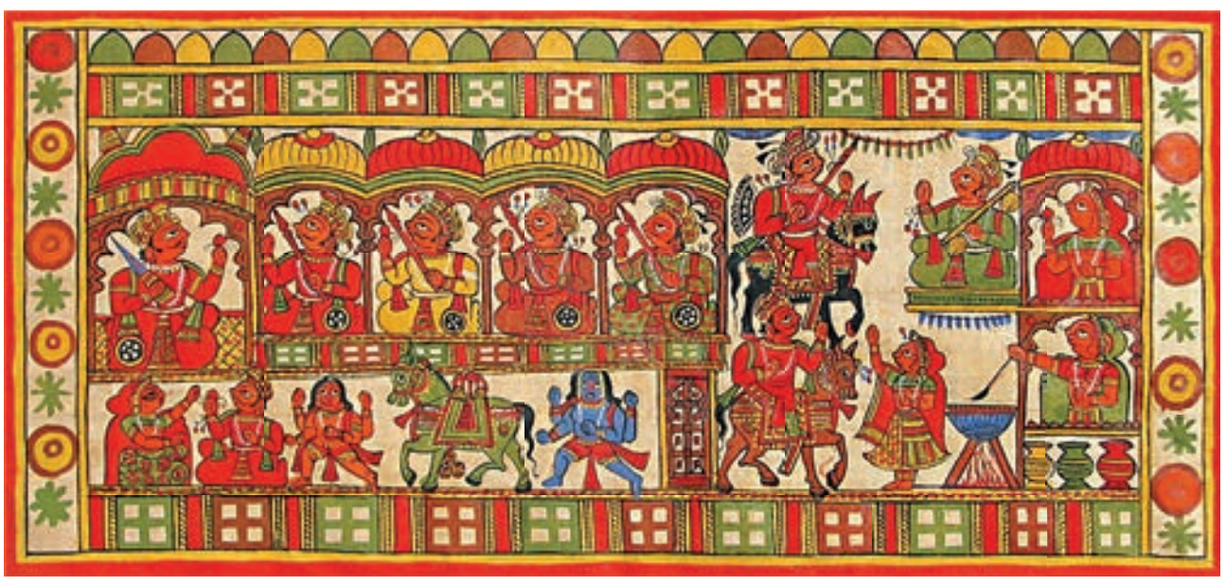
A traditional *pata* was painted on a canvas made of jute fibre. Now, it is made by stitching together sheets of commercial poster paper. The colours come from plants such as marigold, indigo, teak leaves, saffron and turmeric. They also use lamp black. The colours are mixed in coconut shells with the sap of the bael tree (wood apple) which acts as a glue. After finishing, a thin cotton cloth is glued to the back of the painting so that it will last long. Next, the completed scrolls are dried in the sun before they are stored in rolled up bundles.

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Today the *patuas* make rectangular and square-shaped paintings of different sizes. Social messages like conservation of trees, female infanticide, child-trafficking and AIDS awareness figure in their paintings. They also paint images of traditional subjects, such as a cat eating a lobster or fish, tigers, rows of cows or white owls. The patuas today do not make too many long story scrolls. A few of them still sing their self-composed songs but only on demand.

The *patachitra* art tradition was traditionally passed down from father to son but today many patua women have also taken up the craft. Under an initiative 'Art for Livelihood', some of these women are leading local development.



Patachitra

Since 2010, an annual three-day festival *Pot Maya* has been held to celebrate the success of the local artists. Held in November every year, the festival exhibits modern paintings as well as scrolls dating back hundreds of years. At this time, the villagers paint the mud walls of their houses with colourful *patachitra* motifs and hang scrolls on ropes in the courtyards. They also clean up the surroundings and decorate the entire village with flowers to get ready for visitors. As there are no hotels in the village, the visitors stay in tents.

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